

musician. In 1721, he accepted an invitation to become cantor of Hamburg's famous Johanneum and the musical director of its five main churches; he increased his workload the following year by becoming director of the city's Gänsemarkt Oper, Germany's first public opera house.

Marital issues and workload

Telemann's first wife had died in 1711. His second wife, his junior by 17 years, with whom he had eight sons and one daughter, had an affair with a Swedish military official that was satirized in a Hamburg marionette play in 1724. She also racked up heavy gambling debts, paid off with help from her husband's friends, before finally leaving home in 1736.

Telemann's productivity in Hamburg alone was superhuman. But he still found time to freelance for the Bayreuth and Eisenach courts; write three autobiographies; maintain friendships with Bach and Handel; create the first German-language music periodical; correspond with talented young composers, including his godson C.P.E. Bach; teach composition; write poetry; broaden the bounds of what a musician could be; and even take up gardening. He remained active as a composer into his eighties and was still exploring the latest musical styles shortly before his death in 1767.

After his death, Telemann was airbrushed from history, partly because he was overshadowed by Bach and Handel. However, in recent years, performers have revived select pieces from his *Tafelmusik* (Table Music) of 1733—a vast survey of almost every instrumental genre of the day—and championed works